media (both national and regional). Our jobs ranged from setting the agenda and tone for the daily press conferences to communicating the programme to the media, satisfying their multiple queries, coordinating for any special story requirements and dealing with security hurdles (including barring the media personnel from entering, which can be a harrowing job).

The media, true to its nature, would experiment with novel ways to chase an exclusive story by trying to circumvent the security, the party organization, the many bystanders and, of course, us, the hapless coordinators. We had to balance their eternal quest for an exclusive with the Yatra's integrity with great patience and tact. Every day was spent in figuring out newer excuses that would prevent any unsolicited intrusion, and yet ensure a constructive discourse. Over the course of the first few weeks, I noticed a clear difference between the regional and the national media. While they were united in their competitive clamour for access, the regional media was genuinely interested in covering the Yatra. The infectious vibe of the grand adventure we were on and their curiosity about all of us were evident. The media was equally affected by it, and its reportage was consequently profuse both on the national and the regional platforms, as well as the conventional and digital ones. The only difference was in the nature of nuances they brought up. They were responding to the local craving for tales of the Yatra.

However, with time, I began noticing a slight change in the national media, which began to put out speculative and frankly bogus stories on the Yatra. I was quite astonished at how different the national media's portrayal of the Bharat Jodo was from the reality I was seeing every minute with my own eyes. If there was any doubt about whether there was a compromised media in India, my experience put to rest those thoughts. It was abundantly clear that sections of the national media were deliberately furthering a line of argument that was beneficial to the Bharatiya Janata Party and was completely out of touch with reality. I was reminded of the former Chief Justice of India N.V. Ramana, who had commented once that 'when a media house has other business interests, it becomes vulnerable to external pressures. Often, the business interests prevail over the spirit of independent